

STAAR-Aligned RLA Lesson Plans — Grades 3-5

5 Fun & Engaging Lessons with STAAR 2.0 Practice Built In

Lesson 1: Story Detective

Grade: 3rd **TEKS:** 3.6F (Make inferences and use evidence to support understanding), 3.7C (Use text evidence to support an appropriate response)
Duration: 60 minutes **Materials:** Short mystery passages (provided below), "Detective Notebook" sheets (printed), magnifying glasses (optional fun prop), highlighters, anchor chart paper, sticky notes

Learning Objective

I can make inferences about a story using clues from the text and explain my thinking with evidence.

STAAR Connection

Inference questions are among the **most common** on STAAR RLA. STAAR 2.0 requires students to cite specific text evidence in constructed responses — not just pick an answer.

Warm-Up (8 minutes): "What's the Story?"

Display this short paragraph WITHOUT revealing the title:

She pulled on her rubber boots and grabbed the big yellow umbrella from the hook by the door. Through the window, she could see the puddles forming on the sidewalk. "I hope the flowers are okay," she muttered, picking up the watering can and putting it back in the closet.

Think-Pair-Share:

1. What's the weather like? How do you know? (Raining — boots, umbrella, puddles)
2. Why did she put the watering can away? (The rain will water the flowers)

3. Where is she probably going? (Outside — she's getting ready to go out)

Teacher says: "You just made *INFERENCES*! You used clues from the text + what you already know to figure out things the author didn't directly say. Today, you're going to become *Story Detectives* — finding clues and solving reading mysteries!"

Anchor chart: Post and build throughout the lesson:

INFERENCE = Text Clue + What I Already Know

Main Activity (25 minutes): "Mystery Passages"

Phase 1: Guided Practice (10 min)

Read aloud **Mystery Passage #1:**

Marcus sat on the bench and watched the other kids run onto the field. He looked down at his ankle, wrapped tightly in a bandage. Coach Rivera walked over and handed him a clipboard and pencil. "I need you to keep track of everyone's time for the sprints," Coach said. Marcus forced a smile. "Sure, Coach."

Whole-class detective work (teacher models on anchor chart):

Clue from the Text	What I Already Know	My Inference
"Watched the other kids run"	If you're watching, you're not playing	Marcus can't participate in practice
"Ankle wrapped in bandage"	Bandages mean injury	Marcus hurt his ankle
"Forced a smile"	"Forced" means not natural	Marcus is disappointed/sad but trying to be positive
Coach gave him a clipboard job	Coaches include injured players	Coach wants Marcus to still feel part of the team

Model constructed response: "Marcus is probably feeling disappointed because he can't practice with his team. I know this because the text says he 'forced a smile,' which means the smile wasn't real. He also 'watched the other kids run' instead of joining them, which shows he wanted to be out there."

Phase 2: Partner Detective Work (15 min)

Partners receive **2 Mystery Passages** in "Detective Notebook" format.

Mystery Passage #2:

Abuela wiped the flour from her hands and peeked into the oven. The kitchen smelled like cinnamon and sugar. Sofia stood on her step stool, carefully pressing a cookie cutter into the dough. "Abuela, can I put the

sprinkles on this time?" she asked. Abuela smiled and pulled the jar of rainbow sprinkles from the shelf. "Just like I taught your mama," she said softly.

Detective Notebook:

Question	My Answer	Text Evidence (copy the exact words)
What are Abuela and Sofia doing?		
How does Abuela feel about baking with Sofia?		
What can you infer about Abuela and Sofia's mama?		
What kind of relationship do Abuela and Sofia have?		

STAAR Constructed Response:

What can the reader infer about why Abuela said "Just like I taught your mama"? Use evidence from the text to support your answer.

Mystery Passage #3:

The house was quiet when Jayden got home. No TV sounds from the living room. No smell of dinner cooking. Just a note on the kitchen counter: "Jayden — leftovers in the fridge. Dad and I will be late. Feed Biscuit. Love, Mom." Jayden sighed, pulled the container from the fridge, and sat down at the table alone. Biscuit padded over and rested his head on Jayden's knee.

Detective Notebook:

Question	My Answer	Text Evidence
Is Jayden home alone? How do you know?		
Who is Biscuit?		
How is Jayden feeling?		
What can you infer about Jayden's parents' schedule?		

Multi-Select (STAAR format):

Which inferences are supported by the text? Select ALL.

- ☐ Jayden is used to being home alone sometimes
- ☐ Jayden's parents don't care about him
- ☐ Biscuit is Jayden's pet dog
- ☐ Jayden is feeling lonely
- ☐ Jayden's mom prepared food before leaving
- ☐ Jayden is angry at his parents

Correct: Used to it (there's a routine with the note) ✓; Biscuit is a dog (padded over, rested head on knee) ✓; Lonely (sighed, sat alone) ✓; Mom prepared food (leftovers in fridge, note) ✓

Practice (17 minutes): Independent STAAR Practice

Passage:

The last box was the heaviest. Mia's arms ached as she carried it up the narrow stairs. She set it down in the small room and looked around. The walls were blank white. No posters. No photos. Nothing that said "this is Mia's room." Through the window, she could see a street she didn't recognize. A kid on a bike waved at her. Mia waved back, surprised.

"You okay up there?" Mom called from downstairs.

"Yeah," Mia said, though she wasn't sure if that was true. She opened the box and pulled out her favorite blanket — the purple one with the stars. She spread it on the bed. Okay. That was one familiar thing.

Question 1 (Constructed Response):

What is happening in this passage? Use evidence from the text to explain the situation and how Mia is feeling about it.

Question 2 (Multi-Select):

Which details from the text help the reader infer that Mia has just moved to a new place? Select THREE.

- ☐ She carried the last box upstairs
- ☐ The walls were blank white with no decorations
- ☐ Her arms ached
- ☐ She saw a street she didn't recognize
- ☐ Mom called from downstairs
- ☐ She spread her blanket on the bed

Correct: Last box ✓; Blank walls ✓; Street she didn't recognize ✓

Question 3:

What does the sentence "Okay. That was one familiar thing" tell the reader about Mia? Explain using evidence from the text.

Exit Ticket (5 minutes)

The boy shoved his hands in his pockets and kicked a pebble down the sidewalk. Behind him, the school bus pulled away. He glanced back at the

building one last time, then kept walking.

What can you infer about how the boy feels about school? Write your inference AND the text evidence that supports it.

Differentiation

Group

Modification

ELL

Pre-teach key vocabulary from passages. Provide inference sentence stems: "I think ____ because the text says ____." Allow partners to discuss in native language before writing in English. Provide a visual inference anchor chart (Text Clue + Brain = Inference).

SpEd

Read passages aloud. Highlight key clues together before asking inference questions. Reduce to 1 Mystery Passage instead of 2. Provide word bank for constructed responses. Use graphic organizer with boxes for "clue" and "inference."

GT

Add "Author's Craft" analysis: "WHY did the author choose the words 'forced a smile' instead of just 'smiled'? What effect does that word choice have?" Challenge: write their own mystery passage for a partner to make inferences about.

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Lesson 2: News Reporters



Grade: 4th **TEKS:** 4.9D.i (Recognize characteristics and structures of informational text, including the central idea with supporting evidence), 4.6G (Evaluate details read to determine key ideas) **Duration:** 60 minutes **Materials:** News articles (age-appropriate, printed — 3 different articles), "Reporter's Notebook" sheets, highlighters (2 colors), poster paper, markers, "Press Pass" badges (optional fun)

Learning Objective

I can identify the central idea of an informational text, find supporting evidence, and summarize the key information.

STAAR Connection

STAAR 2.0 heavily tests **central idea identification** and **summarizing skills** with informational text. Students must distinguish between main ideas and supporting details.

Warm-Up (8 minutes): "Headline Challenge"

Teacher says: "News reporters have to summarize *BIG* stories in tiny headlines. Let's practice!"

Read a short paragraph, students write a headline (1 sentence max):

Paragraph 1:

"Last Friday, Oak Elementary held its first-ever Multicultural Festival. Over 200 families attended the event, which featured food from 15 different countries, traditional dances performed by students, and booths where visitors could learn phrases in different languages. Principal Nguyen said it was the most well-attended school event in five years."

Students write a headline on dry erase boards. Share and compare.

- Good: "Oak Elementary's Multicultural Festival Draws 200+ Families"
- Too vague: "School Event" (missing key details)
- Too specific: "Principal Nguyen Said It Was Popular" (detail, not main idea)

Discuss: "What's the difference between a DETAIL and the MAIN IDEA?" → The main idea is what the WHOLE text is mostly about. Details support and explain the main idea.

Main Activity (25 minutes): "Newsroom"

Phase 1: Reporter Training (10 min)

Whole class reads **Article #1** together:

"Local Students Design App to Help Seniors"

A group of fifth graders at Riverside Elementary has created a smartphone app called "HelpHand" that connects senior citizens with teenage volunteers in their neighborhood.

The idea started when student Maya Torres noticed her grandmother struggling to carry groceries from her car. "I thought, what if there was an easy way for seniors to ask for help with little things?" Maya said.

Maya teamed up with four classmates during their school's coding club to build the app. Users can post simple tasks like carrying groceries, changing a lightbulb, or picking up a prescription. Teen volunteers in the area receive a notification and can accept the task.

Since launching two months ago, HelpHand has connected 45 seniors with over 60 teen volunteers. The local Rotary Club donated \$500 to help pay for app hosting costs.

"These kids saw a problem and solved it," said coding club teacher Mr. Abrams. "That's what real-world learning looks like."

The team plans to expand HelpHand to three neighboring cities by summer.

Guided analysis with "Reporter's Notebook":

Step 1: HIGHLIGHT the central idea in YELLOW. (Students identify: students created an app to help seniors)

Step 2: HIGHLIGHT 3 supporting details in BLUE.

- Maya got the idea from watching her grandmother
- The app connects seniors with teen volunteers for simple tasks
- 45 seniors and 60 volunteers have used it in 2 months

Step 3: Write the SUMMARY (teacher models the formula):

Central Idea + Key Supporting Details = Summary

"A group of fifth graders at Riverside Elementary created an app called HelpHand that connects senior citizens with teen volunteers who can help with everyday tasks. The app was inspired by student Maya Torres watching her grandmother struggle with groceries. Since launching, HelpHand has connected 45 seniors with over 60 volunteers and plans to expand to more cities."

Phase 2: Partner Newsroom (15 min)

Partners choose ONE of two articles and complete the Reporter's Notebook independently, then compare with their partner.

Article #2: "School Gardens Growing Across Texas"

More Texas schools are planting gardens as outdoor classrooms, and the results are growing — literally.

A new report from the Texas Education Agency shows that 340 schools across the state now have active school gardens, up from just 85 five years ago. Teachers are using the gardens to teach science, math, nutrition, and even writing.

At Bluebonnet Elementary in Austin, fourth graders measure plant growth weekly and graph the data in math class. "They don't even realize they're doing math," laughed teacher Rosa Gutierrez. "They just think they're gardening."

Research supports the trend. A 2023 study from Texas A&M University found that students who participated in school garden programs scored

12% higher on science assessments and were more likely to eat vegetables at lunch.

But gardens require resources. Seeds, soil, tools, and water all cost money. Many schools rely on parent volunteers and community donations. The Texas Farm Bureau recently announced a \$50,000 grant program to help schools start new gardens.

"Every child deserves to know where their food comes from," said Farm Bureau president Linda Vasquez. "These gardens plant seeds in more ways than one."

Article #3: "The Rise of Audiobooks in Elementary Classrooms"

Walk into a classroom at Pecan Creek Elementary during reading time, and you might see something surprising: students wearing headphones, eyes closed, listening.

Audiobooks are becoming a popular tool in elementary schools across the country. A survey by the National Reading Council found that 67% of elementary teachers used audiobooks in their classrooms last year, up from 38% in 2019.

Supporters say audiobooks help struggling readers access grade-level content. "I have students reading at a first-grade level who can comprehend fifth-grade stories when they listen," said reading specialist Denise Park. "It builds their vocabulary and comprehension without the barrier of decoding."

Critics worry that audiobooks replace actual reading. "Kids need to practice decoding," said literacy researcher Dr. James Monroe. "Listening is not the same skill as reading."

Many teachers find a middle ground. At Pecan Creek, students listen to an audiobook while following along in the physical book. "They're seeing the words while hearing the fluency," said teacher Marcus Hill. "It's the best of both worlds."

Whether you're a fan or a skeptic, one thing is clear: audiobooks aren't going away. Sales of children's audiobooks grew 28% last year, and apps like Epic! and Audible are expanding their kids' libraries.

Reporter's Notebook Template:

ARTICLE TITLE: _____

1. CENTRAL IDEA (one sentence):

2. THREE KEY SUPPORTING DETAILS:

- a. _____
- b. _____

C. _____

3. TEXT FEATURES I NOTICED:

- | | |
|---|---|
| ☐ Quote from expert/person | ☐ Statistics/numbers |
| ☐ Cause and effect | ☐ Compare and contrast |
| ☐ Problem and solution | ☐ Chronological order |

4. SUMMARY (3–4 sentences):

5. MY OPINION: Do you think this is an important topic? Why?

Practice (17 minutes): STAAR-Format Questions

Using whichever article they read:

Question 1 (Constructed Response):

What is the central idea of this article? Explain using at least two details from the text to support your answer.

Question 2 (Multi-Select):

For Article #2:

Which details BEST support the central idea that school gardens are beneficial? Select TWO.

- ☐ 340 schools now have active gardens
- ☐ Students scored 12% higher on science assessments
- ☐ Seeds, soil, and tools cost money
- ☐ Fourth graders measure plant growth and graph it in math
- ☐ The Texas Farm Bureau announced a grant program

Correct: 12% higher scores ✓; measuring/graphing in math ✓

For Article #3:

Which details BEST show both sides of the audiobook debate? Select TWO.

- ☐ 67% of teachers use audiobooks
- ☐ Struggling readers can access grade-level content by listening
- ☐ Audiobook sales grew 28%
- ☐ Listening is not the same skill as reading
- ☐ Students wear headphones during reading time

Correct: Access grade-level content ✓; Listening is not reading ✓

Question 3:

Which sentence from the article BEST reveals the author's perspective on the topic? Explain why you chose that sentence.

Exit Ticket (5 minutes)

Read the paragraph below. Write the central idea in ONE sentence.

"Recess isn't just playtime — it's brain time. Studies show that students who get at least 20 minutes of recess daily perform better on tests, have fewer behavior problems, and are more focused in class. Despite this, many schools have cut recess to make more time for instruction. Experts say that's a mistake. 'The brain needs breaks to process learning,' said Dr. Anna Kim, a child development researcher. 'Cutting recess actually hurts academic performance.'"

Central idea:

Differentiation

Group

Modification

ELL

Pre-teach vocabulary (central idea, supporting detail, summarize). Provide articles with key vocabulary glossed in margins. Allow summary writing in native language first, then translate. Sentence stems: "This article is mainly about _____. One detail that supports this is _____."

SpEd

Use Article #1 (read aloud together) for all students. Provide central idea as multiple choice instead of open-ended. Highlight key sentences in advance. Reduce summary to 1-2 sentences. Provide graphic organizer with "Main Idea" in center and "Detail" branches.

GT

Compare two articles: "How do both articles use quotes from experts? What effect does this have on the reader?" Write their own news article about a school topic using the text structures they identified. Analyze author's bias/perspective.

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Lesson 3: Poetry Slam

Grade: 5th **TEKS:** 5.6G (Evaluate details read to determine key ideas), 5.6H (Synthesize information to create new understanding) **Duration:** 60 minutes

Materials: Poems (printed — 4 poems provided below), "Poetry Analysis" sheets, highlighters, dry erase boards, optional: microphone prop for performances

Learning Objective

I can analyze poetry by identifying figurative language, explaining its effect, and determining the poem's theme.

STAAR Connection

STAAR 2.0 requires students to **analyze how poetic devices contribute to meaning** and **identify theme** — going beyond surface-level comprehension.

Warm-Up (8 minutes): "Figurative Language Showdown"

Display sentences one at a time. Students write on dry erase boards whether it's a **simile, metaphor, personification, hyperbole, alliteration, or onomatopoeia** — and what it means literally.

1. "The wind whispered through the trees." → **Personification** (wind can't whisper)
2. "She was as brave as a lion." → **Simile** (comparing bravery to a lion using "as")
3. "Time is money." → **Metaphor** (comparing time to money without like/as)
4. "I've told you a million times!" → **Hyperbole** (exaggeration)
5. "The buzzing bees bounced between blooms." → **Alliteration** (repeating 'b') + **Onomatopoeia** (buzzing)
6. "The sun smiled down on the parade." → **Personification** (sun can't smile)

Quick review: "Figurative language is the poet's TOOLKIT. Today we're going to see how poets USE these tools to create meaning."

Main Activity (25 minutes): "Poetry Slam Analysis"

Phase 1: Guided Analysis (10 min) — Poem #1

Read aloud (dramatically!) then display:

"The Road Not Taken" (excerpt adapted for elementary) by Robert Frost

Two roads diverged in a yellow wood, And sorry I could not travel both
And be one traveler, long I stood And looked down one as far as I could
To where it bent in the undergrowth;

I took the one less traveled by, And that has made all the difference.

Guided analysis (whole class):

Element	What I Found	What It Means
Figurative language	"Two roads diverged" — metaphor	The roads represent choices in life
Imagery	"yellow wood," "bent in the undergrowth"	Fall setting, can't see what's ahead
Key line	"I took the one less traveled by"	The speaker made an unusual/brave choice
Theme		Our choices shape who we become

Model constructed response: "The theme of this poem is that the choices we make define our lives. The poet uses the metaphor of two roads to represent a decision the speaker had to make. The line 'I took the one less traveled by, and that has made all the difference' shows that choosing the less popular or expected path changed the speaker's life significantly."

Phase 2: Poetry Slam Stations (15 min)

Groups of 3-4 rotate through 3 poem stations (5 min each). At each station, they read the poem aloud, complete the analysis sheet, and prepare to "perform" one stanza.

Poem #2: "Dreams" by Langston Hughes

Hold fast to dreams For if dreams die Life is a broken-winged bird That cannot fly.

Hold fast to dreams For when dreams go Life is a barren field Frozen with snow.

Analysis Sheet:

- Figurative language found: ____ (metaphor: life is a broken-winged bird; metaphor: life is a barren field)
- What do these comparisons mean? ____
- What is the poet's message (theme)? ____
- How does the figurative language help you FEEL the message? ____

Poem #3: "Mother to Son" by Langston Hughes (excerpt)

Well, son, I'll tell you: Life for me ain't been no crystal stair. It's had tacks in it, And splinters, And boards torn up, And places with no carpet on the floor— Bare. But all the time I've been a-climbin' on...

Analysis Sheet:

- What is the "crystal stair" a metaphor for? ____ (an easy, beautiful, perfect life)
- What do "tacks," "splinters," and "torn up boards" represent? ____ (hardships, difficulties)

- What is the mother's message to her son? ____ (keep going even when life is hard)
- Theme: ____

Poem #4: "Oranges" by Gary Soto (adapted excerpt)

The first time I walked With a girl, I was twelve, Cold, and weighted down With two oranges in my jacket. ... I peeled my orange That was so bright against The gray of December That, from some distance, Someone might have thought I was making a fire in my hands.

Analysis Sheet:

- What type of figurative language is "making a fire in my hands"? ____ (metaphor/imagery)
 - What does the bright orange against gray December symbolize? ____ (warmth/happiness against a cold/dull world)
 - How does the poet use contrast? ____ (bright vs. gray, warm vs. cold)
 - Theme: ____
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Practice (17 minutes): STAAR-Format Questions

Using Poem #2 ("Dreams"):

Question 1 (Constructed Response):

How does the poet use figurative language to communicate the importance of dreams? In your response, identify at least one example of figurative language and explain how it helps the reader understand the poet's message.

Question 2 (Multi-Select):

Which statements about the poem "Dreams" are supported by the text?
Select ALL.

- ☐ The poet believes dreams are not important
- ☐ "A broken-winged bird" represents a life without hope or purpose
- ☐ The poet repeats "Hold fast to dreams" for emphasis
- ☐ "A barren field frozen with snow" represents emptiness and coldness
- ☐ The poet is describing a real bird and a real field
- ☐ The poem's theme is about the importance of holding onto your dreams

Correct: Broken-winged bird = hopelessness ✓; Repetition for emphasis ✓; Barren field = emptiness ✓; Theme about holding onto dreams ✓

Using Poem #3 ("Mother to Son"):

Question 3 (Constructed Response):

What is the extended metaphor in this poem? How does the poet develop it throughout the poem to reveal the theme? Use specific evidence from the text.

Question 4:

The mother says "Life for me ain't been no crystal stair." What does this line reveal about the mother's life experiences? What does it suggest about what she wants for her son?

Exit Ticket (5 minutes)

Read this short poem:

My grandmother's hands are maps of everywhere she's been— wrinkled roads of flour and soap, mountains of braided hair, rivers of lullabies.

What figurative language does the poet use? What does it reveal about the grandmother? (2-3 sentences)

Differentiation

Group	Modification
ELL	Pre-teach figurative language terms with visual examples. Provide poems in English and Spanish (Hughes poems have Spanish translations available). Allow oral responses before written. Vocabulary support for unfamiliar words in poems.
SpEd	Focus on Poems #1 and #2 only. Provide figurative language "cheat sheet" with definitions and examples. Use fill-in-the-blank analysis instead of open-ended. Read poems aloud multiple times. Provide sentence starters for all written responses.
GT	Compare two poems by the same author (both Hughes poems) — how does the poet use different metaphors to explore similar themes? Write their own poem using at least 3 types of figurative language. Analyze the effect of the poem's structure (line breaks, stanzas) on meaning.

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Lesson 4: Debate Club

Grade: 4th-5th **TEKS:** 4.11B (Develop drafts into a focused piece of writing by developing and organizing ideas), 5.11B (Develop drafts into a focused, structured, and coherent piece of writing by developing an engaging idea with relevant details)
Duration: 60 minutes **Materials:** Debate topic cards (provided), "Argument Builder" graphic organizer (printed), example constructed responses (displayed), sticky notes, chart paper, timer

Learning Objective

I can write a well-organized argument with a clear claim, supporting reasons, and text evidence.

STAAR Connection

STAAR 2.0's **constructed response** prompts often require students to take a position and support it with evidence. Argumentative/opinion writing is a core tested skill.

Warm-Up (8 minutes): "Take a Stand"

Teacher says: "I'm going to read a statement. Move to the *LEFT* side of the room if you *AGREE*, the *RIGHT* side if you *DISAGREE*, and stay in the *MIDDLE* if you're *unsure*."

Statement: "Students should be allowed to use their phones during lunch."

After students move: "Turn to someone near you and explain *WHY* you're standing where you are. You have 60 seconds."

Bring class back. Ask 2-3 students from each side to share. **Key teaching moment:**

"Notice how [student name] didn't just say 'because I want to.' They gave a *REASON*. And [other student] used an example to support their point. *THAT'S* what strong arguments do — they have a clear opinion *AND* reasons/evidence to back it up."

Post the Argument Formula:

Strong Argument = Claim + Reasons + Evidence

Main Activity (25 minutes): "Debate Prep & Mini-Debates"

Phase 1: Argument Builder (12 min)

Each student receives an "Argument Builder" graphic organizer and chooses *ONE* debate topic:

Debate Topics:

- A) Should homework be eliminated?
- B) Should school start one hour later?
- C) Should students choose what they learn in school?
- D) Should schools replace textbooks with tablets?

Argument Builder Graphic Organizer:

MY CLAIM (my opinion in one clear sentence):

REASON #1: _____

Evidence/Example: _____

REASON #2: _____

Evidence/Example: _____

REASON #3: _____

Evidence/Example: _____

COUNTERARGUMENT (what the other side would say):

MY RESPONSE TO THE COUNTERARGUMENT:

CONCLUSION (restate claim in a new way):

Teacher circulates and helps students strengthen weak reasons. Key coaching:

- "That's an opinion — can you support it with a fact or example?"
- "Your reason and evidence are the same thing. The reason tells WHY; the evidence PROVES it."
- "What would someone who disagrees say? How would you respond?"

Phase 2: Mini-Debates (13 min)

Students find a partner who chose a DIFFERENT side of the same topic (or a different topic). Each partner gets 90 seconds to present their argument. Then 60 seconds for rebuttal.

Debate Structure:

1. Partner A presents their argument (90 sec) 🕒
2. Partner B presents their argument (90 sec) 🕒
3. Partner A responds to one of B's points (60 sec) 🕒
4. Partner B responds to one of A's points (60 sec) 🕒
5. Both partners: "What was the strongest point the other person made?" (share out)

Practice (17 minutes): STAAR Constructed Response Writing

Prompt:

Some people think that recess should be longer for elementary students. Others think the time should be used for more learning.

Write a response explaining YOUR position. Support your argument with at least TWO reasons and specific evidence or examples. Address what someone who disagrees might say.

Students write independently. Teacher displays the scoring criteria:

Strong Response Includes:

-  Clear claim/position in the first sentence
-  At least 2 reasons that support the claim
-  Specific examples or evidence for each reason
-  Addresses a counterargument
-  Conclusion that restates the claim
-  Transition words (First, Additionally, However, In conclusion)
-  Complete sentences with correct grammar

Example strong response (display AFTER students write):

"I believe recess should be longer for elementary students because physical activity improves academic performance and student well-being. First, studies have shown that students who get more physical activity during the day score higher on tests and are better able to focus in class. For example, when our class comes back from recess, we are calmer and ready to learn. Additionally, longer recess gives students time to develop social skills through unstructured play. Students learn to solve conflicts, take turns, and collaborate — skills that textbooks can't teach.

Some people argue that longer recess takes away from learning time. However, if students are more focused after physical activity, the instruction time that remains is actually more productive.

In conclusion, extending recess would benefit both students' minds and bodies, making the overall school day more effective."

Exit Ticket (5 minutes)

Write a 3-sentence argument for OR against this statement: "All students should learn to cook in school."

Sentence 1: Your claim Sentence 2: Your strongest reason with evidence
Sentence 3: Your conclusion

Differentiation

Group

Modification

ELL	Provide sentence frames: "I believe ____ because _____. For example, _____. Some people might say _____, but I think _____ because _____." Word bank with transition words. Allow verbal debate in native language, written response in English.
	Provide partially completed Argument Builder (claim given, one reason given — student adds one more). Reduce written response to 1 reason + 1 evidence (instead of 2). Provide a checklist to self-monitor writing. Allow voice-to-text for written response.
SpEd	
GT	Require 3+ reasons with evidence from outside knowledge. Must include a STRONG counterargument with rebuttal. Challenge: write arguments for BOTH sides of the same topic. Analyze persuasive techniques (ethos, pathos, logos — introduce these terms).

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Lesson 5: Book Club Challenge

Grade: 3rd-5th (multi-grade adaptable) **TEKS:** 3.6G (Evaluate details read to determine key ideas), 4.6H (Synthesize information to create new understanding), 5.6H (Synthesize information to create new understanding) **Duration:** 60 minutes
Materials: Paired passage sets (provided below — 2 passages per set), "Reading Detective" comparison sheets, highlighters (2 colors), sticky notes, dry erase boards

Learning Objective

I can read two related passages, identify connections between them, and synthesize information to create new understanding.

STAAR Connection

Paired passages are a signature feature of STAAR RLA. Students must read two related texts and answer questions that require comparing, contrasting, and synthesizing information across both.

Warm-Up (8 minutes): "Two Truths and a Connection "

Display two short, unrelated-seeming facts:

- Fact 1: "Honey never spoils. Archaeologists found 3,000-year-old honey in Egyptian tombs that was still edible."
- Fact 2: "Bees must visit about 2 million flowers to make one pound of honey."

Think-Pair-Share: "What CONNECTION can you make between these two facts?"

Possible connections: Both are about honey; the amount of work bees do (Fact 2) makes it more impressive that honey lasts so long (Fact 1); nature creates incredible things.

Teacher says: *"Finding connections between different texts is a SUPERPOWER on STAAR. Today, you'll read PAIRED PASSAGES — two texts about the same topic — and practice making connections between them."*

Main Activity (25 minutes): "Book Club Challenge"

Phase 1: Guided Paired Passage (12 min)

Read both passages together as a class:

Passage Set A — Topic: Animal Adaptations

Passage 1: "The Arctic Fox's Winter Coat"

The Arctic fox is one of nature's best survivors. As winter approaches and temperatures drop to -50°F, this small fox undergoes a remarkable transformation. Its brown summer fur turns completely white, providing camouflage against the snow. The white coat is also 200% thicker than the summer coat, trapping body heat like a warm blanket.

But the adaptations don't stop at fur. The Arctic fox has small, rounded ears that minimize heat loss. Its paws are covered in thick fur — even on the bottom — acting like built-in snow boots. When temperatures become extreme, the fox curls into a tight ball, wrapping its bushy tail over its face like a scarf.

These adaptations allow the Arctic fox to survive in one of Earth's harshest environments without migrating to warmer climates.

Passage 2: "The Saharan Silver Ant"

In the Sahara Desert, surface temperatures can exceed 150°F — hot enough to cook an egg. Yet the Saharan silver ant thrives in these deadly conditions, earning the title of the most heat-tolerant land animal on Earth.

The ant's secret is its unique hair. Unlike most animals that use hair for warmth, the Saharan silver ant's hairs are triangular-shaped and reflect sunlight like tiny mirrors. This reflective coat keeps the ant's body up to 10 degrees cooler than the surrounding air.

The ants also move incredibly fast — covering 108 body lengths per second (the equivalent of a human running 400 mph). Speed is essential because the ants can only survive above ground for about 10 minutes before overheating. They dash out, grab food, and dash back to their underground burrows.

Both their reflective hair and extraordinary speed are adaptations that allow these tiny creatures to live where almost nothing else can.

Guided comparison (whole class):

Element	Passage 1 (Arctic Fox)	Passage 2 (Silver Ant)
Environment	Arctic, -50°F	Sahara Desert, 150°F+
Main adaptation	White fur, thick coat for warmth	Reflective hair for cooling
How fur/hair helps	Traps heat, provides camouflage	Reflects sunlight, reduces heat
Other adaptations	Small ears, furry paws, tail as scarf	Speed (108 body lengths/sec)
Key idea	Survives extreme cold	Survives extreme heat

Discussion: "These passages are about DIFFERENT animals in DIFFERENT environments. But what's the BIG IDEA that connects them both?"

→ **Synthesis:** Animals develop specific physical adaptations to survive in their extreme environments. Even though the environments are opposite (freezing vs. scorching), the adaptation strategy is similar: the body changes to protect against the extreme temperature.

Phase 2: Partner Book Club (13 min)

Partners choose Passage Set B or C:

Passage Set B — Topic: Kids Making a Difference

Passage 1: "Ryan's Well"

In 1998, six-year-old Ryan Hreljac from Canada learned that people in Africa were dying because they didn't have clean water. Most kids would have felt sad and moved on. Ryan decided to do something.

He started doing extra chores to earn money — \$2 at a time. When he learned that a well costs \$2,000, he didn't give up. He kept working and started speaking at schools and churches. Word spread. Donations poured in.

By the time Ryan was eight, his first well was built in a village in Uganda. Today, Ryan's Well Foundation has built over 1,300 water projects in 16 countries, bringing clean water to more than one million people.

"I just wanted to help," Ryan says. "I didn't know it would become this big."

Passage 2: "Marley's Coats"

When Marley Dias was eleven years old, she was frustrated. "I was tired of reading about white boys and their dogs," she said. Marley, a Black girl from New Jersey, wanted to see characters who looked like her in the books she read at school.

Instead of just complaining, Marley launched #1000BlackGirlBooks, a campaign to collect and donate 1,000 books featuring Black girl protagonists. She set up collection drives, appeared on talk shows, and rallied support on social media.

Marley didn't just hit her goal — she crushed it. She collected over 13,000 books and donated them to schools and communities across the country. She also wrote her own book, *Marley Dias Gets It Done: And So Can You!*

"If you see a problem," Marley says, "you can be the solution."

Comparison Sheet:

1. What problem did each person see?
2. What action did they take?
3. What was the result?
4. What do BOTH passages teach us about making a difference?
5. **Constructed Response:** How are Ryan and Marley similar in the way they approached their goals? Use evidence from BOTH passages to support your answer.

Passage Set C — Topic: Space Exploration

Passage 1: "The First Moon Landing"

On July 20, 1969, astronaut Neil Armstrong stepped onto the surface of the Moon and spoke the famous words: "That's one small step for man, one giant leap for mankind." It was a moment that 600 million people watched on television — the largest TV audience in history at that time.

The journey to the Moon took incredible teamwork. Over 400,000 engineers, scientists, and workers contributed to the Apollo 11 mission. The spacecraft traveled 240,000 miles in just over three days. Armstrong and Buzz Aldrin spent about two hours walking on the Moon, collecting rocks and planting an American flag.

The Moon landing proved that humans could travel beyond Earth. It inspired a generation of scientists, engineers, and dreamers.

Passage 2: "Mars: The Next Frontier"

NASA has a bold goal: send humans to Mars by the late 2030s. But getting to Mars is far more challenging than going to the Moon.

Mars is 140 million miles from Earth — nearly 600 times farther than the Moon. A one-way trip would take about seven months. Astronauts would need to carry enough food, water, and oxygen for years, since there's no quick way to come home if something goes wrong.

The environment is hostile. Mars has almost no atmosphere, temperatures average -80°F, and the soil contains toxic chemicals. NASA is developing new technologies: advanced spacesuits, habitats that can be 3D-printed from Martian soil, and systems to extract water from underground ice.

"Going to Mars is the hardest thing we've ever attempted," said NASA administrator Bill Nelson. "But that's exactly why we should do it."

Comparison Sheet:

1. How far is each destination from Earth?
2. What challenges did/does each mission face?
3. How did/will technology help?
4. **Multi-Select:** Which statements are supported by BOTH passages? Select ALL.
 - ☐ Space exploration requires advanced technology
 - ☐ Both missions were completed successfully
 - ☐ Humans are driven to explore beyond Earth
 - ☐ Teamwork is essential for space missions
 - ☐ Mars is easier to reach than the Moon

Correct: Advanced technology ✓; Driven to explore ✓; Teamwork ✓

Practice (17 minutes): STAAR-Format Paired Passage Questions

Using whichever passage set they read:

Question 1 (Constructed Response):

What THEME or BIG IDEA connects both passages? Use at least one detail from EACH passage to support your answer.

Question 2 (Multi-Select):

Which of the following are similarities between the two passages? Select ALL that apply. (*Specific options depend on passage set chosen — see above*)

Question 3:

How does reading BOTH passages give you a better understanding of the topic than reading just one? Explain.

Exit Ticket (5 minutes)

In one sentence, explain the MOST IMPORTANT connection between the two passages you read today. Then explain WHY that connection matters.

Differentiation

Group

Modification

ELL

Pre-teach vocabulary from passages. Provide comparison graphic organizer (Venn diagram) pre-labeled. Sentence stems: "Both passages are about _____. Passage 1 shows _____ while Passage 2 shows _____. Together, they teach us _____." Read passages aloud.

SpEd

Use Passage Set A only (guided version). Pre-highlight key details in each passage. Provide the comparison chart partially completed. Reduce written response to filling in a cloze paragraph. Allow verbal responses recorded by teacher.

GT

Add a third passage on the same topic — how does it extend understanding? Write a synthesis paragraph that creates a NEW CLAIM based on information from both passages. Evaluate: which passage makes a stronger argument? Why? Analyze how each author's word choice affects tone.

Grade-Level Adjustments

- **3rd Grade:** Use Passage Sets A or B. Focus on identifying similarities and differences (Venn diagram). Written responses can be shorter (2-3 sentences).
 - **4th Grade:** All passage sets. Focus on evaluating key details across both texts. Full constructed responses expected.
 - **5th Grade:** All passage sets. Focus on SYNTHESIS — creating new understanding by combining information from both. Include analysis of author's purpose and perspective.
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